Lesson 16 material: Vocabulary Strategies: Unfamiliar Words and Context Clues

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

1.10: Dealing with Unfamiliar Vocabulary

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What to do when you find unfamiliar words

When you are reading, you will often find words you do not know. You may want to look all of those words up in a dictionary. However, that will slow down your reading *a lot* and it often does not even make it easier to understand the text or remember the words. Instead, underline the new words and keep reading if you can. You can check all of the underlined words at the end and decide if you want to look them up and study them.

However, if you come across the same word several times, or if the word is keeping you from understanding the whole text, you can try a vocabulary strategy. We will look practice three vocabulary strategies:

1. Using context clues
2. Understanding words through their structure (roots, prefixes, suffixes)
3. Using a dictionary and other reference tools

Context clues

Context clues are all of the words *around* a word that will help you to figure out the meaning of that word. Three types of context clues are:

- Brief definition or restatement
- Synonyms and antonyms
- Examples

Brief definition or restatement

Sometimes a text directly states the definition or a restatement of the unknown word. The brief definition or restatement is signaled by a word or a punctuation mark. Consider the following example:

- What does **deportation** mean?
  - **Deportation,** or the removal from a country, can occur when immigrants lack legal papers.
- What does **apprehension** mean?
  - The majority of **apprehensions** or arrests of undocumented immigrants take place on the border.

Synonyms and antonyms

A synonym is a word with the same meaning. An antonym is a word with the opposite meaning (look for the word *but).*

- What does **reside** mean?
  - While more immigrants **reside** in the United States with legal papers (73% of immigrants), about 10.5 million live in the U.S. as undocumented immigrants.
- What does **reform** mean?
  - Most U.S. citizens see a need for immigration **reform**, but a small percentage of people want current immigration policies to remain the same.

Examples

Sometimes you can guess the meaning of a word by looking at the examples that are given. What do these examples all show?

- What does **barrier** mean?
  - Families who choose to travel to the United States face many **barriers**, including a difficult trip across the border, few resources, and the possibility of deportation,
- What does **activist** mean?
  - DACA was made possible by **activists** such as Jose Antonio Vargas and organizations who advocated for social and political change.

Understanding words through the word structure

The English language contains an enormous and ever-growing number of words. Enhancing your vocabulary by learning new words can seem overwhelming, but if you know the common prefixes and suffixes of English, you will understand many more words.

Prefixes

A prefix is a word part added to the beginning of a word to create a new meaning. Study the common prefixes in Table 1.9.1:

Table 1.9.1 Common prefixes, their meaning, and an example word

Prefix	Meaning	Example
dis	not, opposite of	dis + satisfied = dissatisfied

mis	wrongly	mis + spell = misspell
un	not	un + acceptable = unacceptable
re	again	re + election = reelection
inter	between	inter + related = interrelated
pre	before	pre + pay = prepay
non	not	non + sense = nonsense
super	above	super + script = superscript
sub	under	sub + merge = submerge
anti	against, opposing	anti + bacterial = antibacterial

Suffixes

A suffix is a word part added to the end of a word to create a new meaning. They also indicate the part of speech, for example, is the word a noun, adjective, verb, or adverb?

Suffixes that create verbs

Many suffixes used in academic English create verbs. See Table 1.9.2 for the most common verb suffixes. If you add a verb suffix to a noun or adjective, it becomes a verb. For example, if you add the suffix *-en* to the adjective *short,* you get the verb *shorten*, to become short.

Table 1.9.2 Common suffixes that create verbs, with examples

suffix	meaning	examples
-en	become	shorten, awaken
-ify	make or become	simplify, classify, justify
-ise/ize	become	symbolize, visualize

Suffixes that create nouns

The following suffixes create nouns. See Table 1.9.3 for the most common noun suffixes. For instance, if you take the verb *demonstrate* and add the noun suffix *-tion,* you get the noun *demonstration*.

Table 1.9.3 Common suffixes that create nouns, with examples

suffix	meaning	examples
-al	action or process of	denial, refusal
-ant/ -ent	performer of an action	assistant, consultant
-cy	state or quality	efficiency, fluency
-ence/ -ance	state or quality of	preference, dependence
-er	person who does an action	teacher, helper
-ity	quality of	ability, similarity
-ment	condition	punishment, development
-ness	state of being	darkness, preparedness
-ship	position held	citizenship, leadership
-tion/ -sion	condition or state of	education, information

Suffixes that create adjectives

These suffixes create adjectives. See Table 1.9.4 for a list of the most common adjective suffixes. As an example, adding the adjective suffix *-ful* to the noun *peace* gives you an adjective, *peaceful.*

Table 1.9.4 Common suffixes that create adjectives, with examples

suffix	meaning	example
-able	capable of being	fixable, avoidable
-al	having the character of	national, professional
-ent	tending towards	excellent, different
-ful	notable for	beautiful, peaceful

-ive	having the nature of	attractive, effective
-less	without	careless, helpless
-ous	characterized by	dangerous, famous

Suffixes that create adverbs

A few suffixes create adverbs. See Table 1.9.5 for the most common adverb suffixes. For instance, adding the adverb suffix *-ly* to the adjective *happy* gives you *happily,* an adverb. Or adding *-ward* to the noun *west* gives you the adverb *westward*, in the direction of the *west*.

Table 1.9.5 Common suffixes that create adverbs, with examples

suffix	meaning	examples
ly/ -ily	related to	softly, carefully
-ward/ -wards	direction	towards, afterwards, backwards
-wise	in relation to	otherwise, likewise, clockwise,

Let's try it

Now let's use these tools to figure out the meaning of some vocabulary.

Try This

Read the following passage from *The Conversation's* " 4 Reasons Why Migrant Children Arriving Alone to the US Create a 'Border Crisis'" by Ediberto Román.

- Do any words have a brief definition or restatement, a synonym or antonym, or an example that shows the meaning?
- Which prefixes and suffixes can you recognize? What do these prefixes and suffixes mean?

"Undocumented immigrants – and particularly children – are not the constituents of any Washington politician. They have no voice within the U.S. democratic system. While journalists can and do report on immigration problems, and public interest law firms can and do represent these children in immigration proceedings, unaccompanied minors are simply not part of any politician's voting bloc or reelection strategy."

Using reference tools

Referencing a dictionary or thesaurus can be helpful, too. For more on using a dictionary or thesaurus, visit the Language Toolkit for Chapter 6.

Dictionary

If a vocabulary word seems critical to understanding a reading passage, and you cannot figure out the meaning from the context or the word structure, you may have to look it up in a dictionary.

Thesaurus

Another reference you can use is a thesaurus. It can help you find words with the same or similar meanings. However, the words cannot just replace each other. Be sure to look at the example sentences to see how the words are used.

Work Cited

Román, Ediberto. " 4 Reasons Why Migrant Children Arriving Alone to the US Create a 'Border Crisis'." *The Conversation,* 31 March 2021.

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6.5: Using Context Clues

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Learning Objectives

1. Identify the different types of context clues.
2. Practice using context clues while reading.

Context clues are bits of information within a text that will assist you in deciphering the meaning of unknown words. Since most of your knowledge of vocabulary comes from reading, it is important that you recognize context clues. By becoming more aware of particular words and phrases surrounding a difficult word, you can make logical guesses about its meaning. The following are the different types of context clues:

- Brief definition or restatement
- Synonyms and antonyms
- Examples

Brief Definition or Restatement

Sometimes a text directly states the definition or a restatement of the unknown word. The brief definition or restatement is signaled by a word or a punctuation mark. Consider the following example:

If you visit Alaska, you will likely see many glaciers, or slow moving masses of ice.

In this sentence, the word *glaciers* is defined by the phrase that follows the signal word *or*, which is *slow moving masses of ice*.

In other instances, the text may restate the meaning of the word in a different way, by using punctuation as a signal. Look at the following example:

Marina was indignant — fuming mad — when she discovered her brother had left for the party without her.

Although *fuming mad* is not a formal definition of the word *indignant*, it does serve to define it. These two examples use signals — the word *or* and the punctuation dashes — to indicate the meaning of the unfamiliar word. Other signals to look for are the words *is*, *as*, *means*, *known as*, and *refers to*.

Synonyms and Antonyms

Sometimes a text gives a synonym of the unknown word to signal the meaning of the unfamiliar word:

When you interpret an image, you actively question and examine what the image connotes and suggests.

In this sentence the word *suggests* is a synonym of the word *connotes*. The word *and* sometimes signals synonyms.

Likewise, the word *but* may signal a contrast, which can help you define a word by its antonym.

I abhor clothes shopping, but I adore grocery shopping.

The word *abhor* is contrasted with its opposite: *adore*. From this context, the reader can guess that *abhor* means to dislike greatly.

Example :

Sometimes a text will give you an example of the word that sheds light on its meaning:

I knew Mark's ailurophobia was in full force because he began trembling and stuttering when he saw my cat, Ludwig, slink out from under the bed.

Although ailurophobia is an unknown word, the sentence gives an example of its effects. Based on this example, a reader could confidently surmise that the word means a fear of cats.

Tip

Look for signal words like such as, for instance, and for example. These words signal that a word's meaning may be revealed through an example.

Exercise :

Identify the context clue that helps define the underlined words in each of the following sentences. Write the context clue on your own sheet of paper.

1. Aisha is very adroit on the balance beam, but Alejandra is rather clumsy.
2. I saw the entomologist, a scientist who studies insects, cradle the giant dung beetle in her palm.
3. Alberto's comments about politics were irrelevant and meaningless to the botanist's lecture on plant reproduction.
4. Before I left for my trip to the Czech Republic, I listened to my mother's sage advice and made a copy of my passport.
5. His rancor, or hatred, for socializing resulted in a life of loneliness and boredom.
6. Azmir was mortified, way beyond embarrassment, when his friends teamed up to shove him into the pool.
7. The petulant four-year-old had a baby sister who was, on the contrary, not grouchy at all.
8. The philosophy teacher presented the students with several conundrums, or riddles, to solve.
9. Most Americans are omnivores, people that eat both plants and animals.
10. Elena is effervescent, as excited as a cheerleader, for example, when she meets someone for the first time.

Exercise :

On your own sheet of paper, write the name of the context clue that helps to define the underlined words.

Maggie was a precocious child, to say the least. She produced brilliant watercolor paintings by the age of three. At first, her parents were flabbergasted—utterly blown away—by their daughter's ability, but soon they got used to their little painter. Her preschool teacher said that Maggie's dexterity, or ease with which she used her hands, was something she had never before seen in such a young child. Little Maggie never gloated or took pride in her paintings; she just smiled contentedly when she finished one and requested her parents give it to someone as a gift. Whenever people met Maggie for the first time they often watched her paint with their mouths agape, but her parents always kept their mouths closed and simply smiled over their "little Monet."

Tip

In addition to context clues to help you figure out the meaning of a word, examine the following word parts: prefixes, roots, and suffixes.

Also, in spoken language, jargon is a type of communication often used in the workplace. It is the technical language of a special field. Imagine it is your first time working as a server in a restaurant and your manager tells you he is going to "eighty-six" the roasted chicken. If you do not realize that "eighty-six" means to remove an item from the menu, you could be confused. You will definitely encounter jargon that will likely be foreign to you when you begin work. If you cannot understand the jargon based on the context, it is always a good policy to ask.

Key Takeaways

- Context clues are words or phrases within a text that help clarify vocabulary that is unknown to you.
- There are several types of context clues including brief definition and restatement, synonyms and antonyms, and example.